

DESIGNING A TRANSITION: FOOD INSECURITY IN PITTSBURGH

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Taking Stock: In this exercise, teams assess the present situation and ask the four questions below in the colored boxes on the left. As an organization or community undertakes an intentional, long-term transition, they must first ask: 1) what about the current system/organization/paradigm isn't working? What is keeping us stuck and needs to go away? 2) What should we keep? 3) What new ideas, initiatives, technologies, practices are "floating around" (either internally or externally) that can disrupt the status quo and help jump start the transition? 4) what new ideas, initiatives, technologies, policies or practices are already present in the world, but we didn't see them before because we didn't have a long term vision? These "fragments" should contain aspects of the long-term vision and can inform both the first milestones on the transition pathway and systems interventions.



NEAR CASTING
5-10 YEARS OUT

Building Awareness About Food Apartheid's + Systemic Inequality: Nation-wide awareness campaigns and documentaries ignite conversations at home and in classrooms leading to reveal the truth about the roots of food insecurity as systemic and not individual. While wider scale change still has not occurred the conversation causes people to question the system at large.

Food Co-ops, A cultural shift is making shopping at co-ops a trendy and socially valued choice, encouraging more people to support local food systems and community-driven sustainability. However, the cost of participation is still out of reach for many low-income residents.

Mobile markets have become common-practice to deliver fresh produce directly to food-deprived neighborhoods. But there are still long lines and people who work late may miss the opportunity to shop at the mobile bus while it's here.

Leadership over land stewardship has been returned to indigenous communities at the local and policy level empowering communities to reclaim traditional foodways by restoring native plants and sustainable harvesting practices on reclaimed land.

NEAR TERM MILESTONE:
this is the scenario we can imagine most clearly and plan strategically for, since it is only 5-10 years out.

MID-CASTING
25-35 YEARS OUT

Activism and Education about the root of food injustice creates cultural awareness that helps to remove the stigma around seeking assistance. Collective action has impacted policy changes and curriculum in school that makes the issue impossible to ignore at all levels of everyday life.

Food Friendly Policy: A new policy mandates that every neighborhood actively contribute to local food sovereignty by fostering community-driven food systems. This includes supporting urban agriculture, farmers' markets, cooperative grocery stores, and culturally relevant food initiatives. The policy promotes equitable access, sustainability, and community decision-making, ensuring that residents have control over their food sources and nutritional well-being.

Mobile Markets now deliver free food to everyone's doorstep, in food-deprived and underserved neighborhoods or to those who have access needs such as disability or aging populations.

An ethical and sustainable alliance has formed between indigenous harvesting practices and technological innovations, leading to the development of closed-loop regional food hubs that rely on aquaponics and vertical farming practices moving us closer to a localized circular economy model.

MID-TERM MILESTONE:
We suggest doing this milestone last so that it can be informed by those on opposite ends of the time continuum. This might be a turning point or breakdown of some kind but might also signal a smooth transition that is underway.

BACKCASTING
50-60 YEARS OUT

Community Wealth Building and Co-Op Initiatives have taken precedent over corporate ownership of community resources like grocery stores, strengthening a localized economy that is connected to other community networks (cosmopolitan localism)

The food supply system has shifted to a decentralized model centered around locally grown produce, replacing traditional grocery stores. This transformation eliminates the need for long-distance food distribution and ensures that fresh, nutritious food is always accessible without requiring travel.

The SNAP program is no longer necessary due to successful advocacy efforts that have led to strong policy changes, ensuring access to culturally relevant food. Government programs have been replaced by localized community initiatives that keep residents healthy.

The focus has shifted from simply growing food to conserving local species, ecosystems, and cultural heritage. Closed-loop regional food hubs now prioritize the restoration and protection of biodiversity, using aquaponics and vertical farming to regenerate local environments while preserving human impact.

